

Introduction

For nearly 20 years, ThinkWorkStories! has been studying and developing stories about the practices and strategies that support people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) to live and work successfully in their communities. Many stories this year focused on the use of self-directed services to achieve competitive integrated employment and community life engagement.

Self-direction is a Medicaid service model that allows people with IDD to directly manage their own services and supports. Research shows that the use of self-directed services significantly enhances quality of life and offers an alternative path to achieving competitive integrated employment (CIE) and community life engagement (CLE) outcomes (Kulchinsky et al., 2021; Caldwell & Heller, 2007; Bogenschutz et al., 2019). Internationally, self-direction is viewed as a valuable service model due to its person-centered nature, individualized approach, and promotion of community integration (Bradley et al., 2021). In the US, nearly one-third of Medicaid Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) have the option for self-direction, which can include a range of employer authority (e.g., hiring and managing staff) and budget authority (e.g., managing HCBS funds; Friedman, 2024).

Although about 80% of states allow self-direction within their HCBS waivers for people with IDD, only about 13% of people with IDD nationwide self-directed their HCBS in FY 2021 (Friedman, 2024). This is despite Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) (2014, 2019) urging states to expand self-direction and make HCBS more person-centered in alignment with the HCBS Settings Rule (CMS, n.d.). This results in missed opportunities to promote choice, individual control, respect, and self-determination, while ensuring full access to work, community involvement, and a fulfilling life.

Integrated employment for people with IDD is impacted by many factors. A person's education level, access to transportation, family support, and level of independent living skills can all serve as potential barriers or facilitators to obtaining and retaining a job in the community (Taubner et al., 2022; Park & Park, 2021). This demonstrates the importance of considering many facets of an individual's life when exploring how to support employment goals and outcomes.

The Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston conducted a qualitative study to learn about the experiences of individuals with IDD who self-direct their employment services. The study aimed to identify strategies and practices that have been effective in achieving employment outcomes. The study conducted semi-structured interviews with people with IDD, their family members and supports brokers from different states across the country to better understand their experiences with self-directed services, resulting in seven individual ThinkWork! stories.

This brief is #2 in a series highlighting the self-directed services strategies people with IDD and their family members use. Brief #2 highlights the stories' findings, which demonstrated the broader ways in which the choice to self-direct services ultimately supports employment, even when the self-directed services were not employment-specific.

Self-Directed Strategies for Success

Throughout the study, it became clear that self-directed services impacted employment in a variety of ways. Due to the interconnectedness of employment and other aspects of an individual's life, self-directing other types of services, like personal care and transportation, was also found to support employment.

Employment Services

Most participants used self-direction for employment services. The choice of self-direction versus other models was influenced by different factors, including the amount of support the person needs while working and the type of supports available in the workplace.

Self-direction of employment services was often used by individuals who benefited from a more consistent job coaching support. Several participants spoke to the consistency and routine that accompanied being able to choose their own on-the-job support persons. One participant shared that through self-directed services, they were able to identify a consistent job coach to provide support every day at work, whereas when they worked with a service agency, they would have a different job coach day-to-day or week-to-week. This participant's family shared how using self-directed services for employment services led to a more consistent routine and an improved quality of life: "He knows the person that he's going to be with for that part of his day. He knows how he's getting home. He knows their name. It's a good feeling." Similarly, another participant reflected on self-directed services for employment services stating: "It means having control over how and when I use services. I decide who supports me and how."

Some participants chose not to use self-directed services for employment services as they had strong natural supports at work or received supports from other state agencies. Two participants spoke to their coworkers serving as natural supports, helping them with writing and typing duties or helping with setting up technology for presentations. Another participant reported that he meets with a tech-focused job coach through the Department of Vocational Rehabilitation, whose role is to observe him while working and recommend technology to his employer that could increase efficiency. This participant also expressed having a supportive workplace that lets him work from home and adjust his schedule around his other needs.

Transportation Services

Several participants spoke about the direct benefits of self-directed transportation services on their lives, specifically in terms of employment outcomes. As one participant shared:

"Transportation really is a lifeline for the disability community. It's one of the biggest unmet needs that Medicaid systems struggle to meaningfully address; to get people living with disabilities where they want to go, when they want to go there."

Using self-direction for transportation allowed several participants to purchase their own vehicles and hire staff to drive them. One participant spoke about the challenges of public transportation, “which is a little tricky” to navigate. The ability to take control over transportation eliminates it as a barrier to employment. In addition, self-directing transportation supported participants to travel to and from healthcare and therapy appointments and activities they enjoyed in the community.

Another participant shared that she uses self-directed funds to purchase transit passes and shared rides to get around her city and to her teaching job. She used her lived experience with transportation barriers to launch her own business and train others about public transit accessibility. She uses self-directed funds to cover her ride costs during these trainings. This example highlights the way self-directed transportation services supported the individual’s part-time teaching job, while also creating space for her to pursue her passion and self-employment.

Wraparound Supports

Participants said that they have self-directed services at home that support their independent living skills. The need for wraparound supports, including attendant support for basic hygiene or mobility needs throughout the day, creates an added element of preparation and time required that individuals shared about when it comes to employment. One participant spoke about this as a challenge:

“At times it’s been more challenging than I anticipated, just because, you know, meeting the expectations [of] the job with accommodations is still meeting the expectations of the job. And so, it can take a lot of energy and effort for, you know me, to make all of this happen. And I’m not sure how you know, I don’t know how much my colleagues understand about the planning and little, little, tiny decisions and things that I have to prepare for to make sure that I’m able to show up.”

Participants shared that self-directing these services created a more stable routine and more time to focus on things they enjoyed. One participant reported that self-direction created the “most person-centered program you could wish for.”

Several participants reported that they work fully or partially remote, and that the support services assisting them at home also make it possible for them to work from home.

Participants spoke about the importance of having someone available to assist with their daily activities related to hygiene, meals, safety, and keeping a routine. One participant referenced the distinction between being home versus being at work for the workday:

“When I’m at work, it’s a little different. It is hard to find support in the middle of the day, to...come and help with certain things that may happen during the day.” Participants who traveled for work rely on the self-directed services supports they have hired to drive them.

The ability to self-direct support also means that individuals can choose their own staff and ensure that they receive support from people they trust, during the hours they need and want them. One participant highlighted this by sharing: “It’s about choosing what’s right for me and not feeling like I have to do it all alone.”

Strategies & Suggestions for People with IDD and Their Families:

- » **Consider self-directed employment services in the greater context of your support needs at and related to your work.** Self-directed services can mean having consistent and trusted support to help someone get ready for work, have reliable transportation, and/or receive regular on-the-job support. The different types of services a person receives provide supports that all connect to a person's ability to find and maintain a fulfilling job.
- » **Having a trusted and reliable network of support is key in all areas of an individual's life.** Self-directed services can provide an individual with employer authority, allowing them to interview and hire their own staff, ensuring they feel confident that staff can properly support their needs.
- » **The option to self-direct services can reduce barriers to employment.** When people need wraparound supports throughout the day, such as support for meeting medical needs and mobility concerns, self-direction gives people more autonomy and control to ensure their needs are met so that they can maintain a stable and reliable routine. Such stability and support for a consistent routine then directly impacts an individual's ability to show up consistently for work.

Conclusion

Self-directed services were reported as a valued service delivery option to support employment for the participants in this study. Participants reported the autonomy and consistency of self-directed services and the positive impact on quality of life and employment. While the researchers intended for the study to focus on self-directed employment services, findings indicated that the use of self-directed services in other areas of life also affected their ability to find and maintain a fulfilling job. Using self-directed services to support independent living and transportation goals reduced barriers to community-based work. Several participants also blended self-directed services with other modes of service delivery to customize plans to meet their needs. These findings highlight the importance of considering how we think about service models, service delivery, and the interconnected nature of different types of services to holistically support needs.

References

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